

Proposed Title

The County Digital Skills and Innovation Hubs Bill, 2026

Sponsor

Sen. Caleb Owens
Senator for Machakos

Nature of Proposal

Senate Bill Affecting Counties

Purpose of the Proposed Legislation

To establish digital innovation and technology hubs in every county to:

- promote youth employment,
- expand digital literacy,
- support startups and innovation,
- provide access to internet and ICT infrastructure,
- support AI and software development training.

Problem the Proposal Intends to Address

Many Kenyan youths lack access to:

- affordable ICT training,
- innovation centers,
- remote work facilities,
- startup incubation opportunities,
- modern digital skills required in the global economy.

Most counties do not have adequately equipped public innovation hubs despite increasing demand for digital jobs and online work opportunities.

Main Objectives

The proposed law seeks to:

1. Require each county government to establish at least one innovation hub.
2. Create a framework for digital skills training programs.
3. Establish partnerships with universities, TVETs, and private technology firms.
4. Provide funding mechanisms for county innovation programs.

5. Support youth-led startups and digital entrepreneurship.

Key Policy Proposals

The Bill is expected to include provisions on:

- establishment of county innovation hubs,
- governance and management structures,
- funding mechanisms,
- digital training programs,
- public-private partnerships,
- startup incubation support,
- monitoring and accountability mechanisms.

Constitutional and Legal Basis

The proposal is based on:

- Article 55 (Youth empowerment),
- Devolution and county development functions,
- Access to education and technology,
- Economic and social development objectives under the Constitution of Kenya.

Financial Implications

The proposal may require:

- annual allocations from county governments,
- conditional grants from the national government,
- partnerships with development organizations and private sector actors.

Expected Impact

The proposed legislation is expected to:

- reduce youth unemployment,
- increase digital literacy,
- improve county innovation capacity,
- promote local software and technology development,
- enhance economic opportunities in rural counties.